POKERBOTS

MIT 6.9630

Massachusetts Institute of Technology
6.9630 Pokerbots Competition

IAP 2026
Lectures MTWR 12:00-1:30 in 6-120
Recitation/Office Hours 2-4 in 26-168
Zoom Link: pkr.bot/zoom

Staff

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Links

Homepage:	pokerbots.org
Resources:	pkr.bot/resources
Piazza:	pkr.bot/piazza
Scrimmage Server:	pkr.bot/scrimmage
Lecture Recordings	pkr.bot/panopto
Canvas page:	pkr.bot/canvas
Find Teammates:	pkr.bot/teammates
Instagram:	pkr.bot/instagram
Github:	pkr.bot/github

Introduction

Pokerbots is an annual month-long programming competition in which students form teams of 1-4 members to create an autonomous poker-playing algorithm (a “pokerbot”). Over the four weeks of IAP, the open-ended project in pokerbot design builds skills in computer science, game theory, mathematics, and machine learning.

Students will learn how to think about developing their pokerbots by attending ~twelve lectures and will have the chance to test their skills in competition against their peers. In class, students will learn about topics ranging from poker strategy to reinforcement learning, and their applications to building a successful pokerbot. A scrimmage server will be run throughout the month allowing teams to challenge each other at any time. There will be a mini tournament at the end of each of the first three weeks. In the fourth week, teams may continue to work on their pokerbots separately. During the final tournament, teams’ finished pokerbots are put to the test in a tournament for exciting prizes.

Poker is a complex yet highly accessible challenge: it’s easy to learn, but difficult to be competitive in. Building a pokerbot is similar, as anyone can make an elementary bot, but building a competitive bot requires a deep understanding of the strategies adopted by other teams and how to contest them. At the heart of the Pokerbots competition is the challenge of applying the algorithmic and strategic thinking taught in theoretical courses.

Evaluation

6.9630 is graded on a pass/fail basis. To receive a passing grade, students are expected to fulfill both of two requirements: participation on the scrimmage server, and completion of a final strategy report. All teams who meet the below requirements in good faith will receive a passing grade.

Participation

Pokerbots is designed to encourage exploration. Students who put more effort into trying new ideas to design a winning pokerbot will have greater learning opportunities and a better chance to win prizes. To earn credit, students are expected to put sustained effort into developing their pokerbots. This will be judged by submissions each week during which each team’s pokerbot will be evaluated for improved performance relative to their previous week’s submission and against a bot that implements a random strategy.

Make-up

If a team fails to submit their pokerbot or improve their pokerbot from one week to the next, that team is expected to submit a half-page double-spaced make-up report describing the attempted improvements for the week and thoughts on why they were unsuccessful. This is intended to avoid penalizing students who explore avenues that do not end up resulting in successful strategies. Make-up reports (if necessary) are due the Tuesday following each mini tournament. Reports should list all team members and be emailed to **pokerbots@mit.edu**

Final Report

To earn credit in this course, each team is required to submit a final strategy report outlining their work up to and including their final pokerbot:

- Submission required from ≥1 member, 3-5 pages, double spaced, PDF format
- Top of first page, must list: Team name and each member's full name and kerb (or email if no kerb)
- **Due Tue 1/27 11:59PM EST** on Canvas: **pkr.bot/canvas**

These reports are meant to catalog the effectiveness of techniques explored throughout the class, as well as describe the distribution of work. In particular, the report should highlight the strategic and/or architectural insights that went into your team's pokerbot, and primary takeaways from the month. Diagrams are optional, but *highly* recommended.

Structure

Over the course of IAP, students have five main touchpoints with the course: class sessions, Piazza, the scrimmage server, Github, and the final event.

Class

There will be twelve lectures in person every Monday through Thursday (6-120, 12-1:30PM), each which will be applicable to developing a successful pokerbot. These lectures will be recorded. Recitation and Office Hours will be held after each lecture (26-168, 2-4PM), as well as on most non-lecture days (info will be posted on Piazza). Each lecture will have provided lunch and one or more giveaways with nice prizes! All of these sessions are available virtually at pkr.bot/zoom, which will be updated to always direct to the correct zoom link.

Piazza

Piazza is an online forum we will be using to answer questions and make announcements. It's important to check Piazza regularly for updates and changes we may make. You can post (publicly or anonymously to everyone or the instructors) and a member of the Pokerbots team will respond as soon as possible (last year, the average response time was less than 5 minutes!). You are also encouraged to answer other students' questions, and we will be rewarding students who contribute the most in this manner over the month. Note that an MIT email address is required to join - if you have issues, please contact the staff.

Scrimmage Server

The scrimmage server is how you will gauge the performance of your pokerbot relative to reference bots and other teams. On the scrimmage server, you can challenge your opponents and keep track of useful bot statistics. We have a Playground feature where you can manually interact with your own or another's pokerbot to get a feel for how it operates in practice and try to beat your bot at the variant! Furthermore, all mini-tournament submissions are done by uploading and selecting your latest bot on the scrimmage server. We'll be giving out prizes based on your performance on the server as well!

Github

Throughout this course we will be posting materials, and additional resources to Github. This is where the Engine repository can be found, as well as any sample code from lecture. We will be uploading slides and a recording after every lecture as well.

Final Event

Pokerbots culminates in a virtual final event on January 30st, 2025. This is where we will announce the winners of the final pokerbots tournament, as well as give out all of our biggest prizes. There will be fun and games, as well as a chance to meet and network with our sponsors directly! More details about the final tournament and event will be posted on the course Piazza as the date approaches.

Other Events

We will be hosting a variety of other events such as afternoon study breaks, poker socials, hackathons, and sponsor networking events. These events are more informal and spontaneous, and information or details would be on Piazza as they approach.

Timeline

Week 1	
Mon 1/5	Lecture 1: Intro to Pokerbots Recitation: Environment Setup
Tue 1/6	No Class: Cancelled
Wed 1/7	Lecture 2: Probability and Statistics Recitation: Poker Social!
Thu 1/8	Lecture 3: Poker Strategy
Fri 1/9	Week 1 Bot due 11:59pm
Sat 1/10	**Mini Tournament #1**
Week 2	
Mon 1/12	Lecture 4: Game Theory Recitation: NumPy and other Stats Packages
Tue 1/13	Lecture 5: Machine Learning
Wed 1/14	Lecture 6: Reinforcement Learning Hackathon!
Thu 1/15	No Class: Hackathon
Fri 1/16	Week 2 Bot due 11:59pm
Sat 1/17	**Mini Tournament #2**
Week 3	
Mon 1/19	No Class: MLK Day
Tue 1/20	Lecture 7: Neural Networks and Optimization
Wed 1/21	Lecture 8: Counterfactual Regret Minimization
Thu 1/22	Lecture 9: Decision Trees
Fri 1/23	Week 3 Bot due 11:59pm
Sat 1/24	**Mini Tournament #3**
Week 4	
Mon 1/26	Lecture 10: Guest: *GTO Wizard*
Tue 1/27	No Class: Final Report/Bot Strategy Report due 11:59pm
Wed 1/28	Lecture 11: Guest: Noam Brown, *OpenAI* Poker Social After! 2-4PM in 32-044 Final Bot due 11:59pm
Fri 1/30	**Pokerbots Final Event:** 4:30-7PM in Kresge
Sat 1/31	Poker Tournament (with Prize Pool)

Prizes

The prize pool for Pokerbots 2025 is over **$50,000.** Here's the breakdown:

Final Tournament Prizes	
First place	$10,000
Second place	$6,500
Third place	$3,500
Fourth place	$2,000
Fifth place	$1,000
First place in language (Python, Java, or C++)	$500 x 3
Second place in language (Python, Java, or C++)	$250 x 3
Third place in language (Python, Java, or C++)	$125 x 3
Best freshman-majority (>51%) team	$2,000

Scrimmage Server Prizes	
Weekly tournament winner	$1,000 x 3
Weekly tournament biggest upset	$500 x 3
Weekly tournament most improved	$750 x 2
Most time at the top of the scrimmage server	$1,000

Miscellaneous Prizes	
Most helpful Piazza students	$250 x 3
Surprise prizes, lightning tournaments, raffles	$15,000

We'll be holding raffles during each of the classes and events for great tech prizes!

Sponsors